nowhere, and fought our way through to a home final in front of our own supporters at the Chinnaswamy, and fallen short. We walked around the field at the end, thanking our supporters, and it was heart-rending to see the disappointment on so many sad faces.

We didn't get back to our hotel until after one o'clock in the morning and there was not much time to rest and reflect because I was booked to leave Bengaluru at seven o'clock the following morning, flying to London and then on to join the Proteas in the Caribbean.

As I settled into my seat on another long-haul flight, sitting beside my wife Danielle who was cradling our young son, I considered just how ridiculously fortunate I have been and continue to be.

How fortunate to be raised by unconditionally loving parents and brothers ... to have such loyal friends and family ... to have married such an incredible and loving wife ... to have been embraced by such wonderful parents-in-law ... to have a beautiful son ... to have made a living by doing something I would have been happy to do for fun.

Looking back on all these years, I feel so enormously grateful to so many people ... to teachers and coaches, to friends and teammates at school ... to everybody at the Titans and Royal Challengers Bangalore ... to each and every person who has shared with me the great honour of being a Protea and representing our country on the cricket field: to the national coaches and selectors, to the officials and staff of Cricket South Africa who work so selflessly to make it possible for people like me to do what we do and take too much of the credit ... to each of the members of the professional team who continue to guide me off the field ... to everyone anywhere in the world who has come to watch the cricket and, by so doing, has made it possible for me to live a life far beyond any of my dreams ... last, but not least, to the talented people at Pan Macmillan, notably Terry Morris and Andrea Nattrass, for the opportunity to write this book.

The flight flew by and, in a quiet moment, my mind switched back to